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The e-Filing Portal, End to End

Every service India's income tax portal offers and the process behind it; who the roughly 9 crore people using it actually are; what breaks when they show up – in their own words – and an eleven-point plan for fixing it.

Operator Central Board of Direct Taxes **Platform** IEC 2.0, live since 7 June 2021

Governing law Income-tax Act, 2025 (w.e.f. 1 Apr 2026)

ORIENTATION			
What the portal is	Registration & login		
CORE SERVICES			
Filing returns	e-Verification	26AS, AIS & TIS	e-Pay Tax
Statutory forms	Deductors & TDS	Refunds	Corrections & relief
Notices & demands	Appeals & disputes	Utility services	Profile & partners
Grievances & support			
THE USER BASE			
Scale	Who files what	User segments	Usage rhythm
REALITY CHECK			
What goes wrong	In users' own words	Workarounds as evidence	Root causes
What improved			
THE FIX			
Nine things to get right	How to fix each one	Sequencing	How to know it worked
Data gaps			

What the portal actually is

Not one system. Four, stitched behind a single login – and knowing which one you are standing in explains most of the confusion users have.

FRONT OFFICE

e-Filing portal – incometax.gov.in

Where you register, file returns and forms, pay tax, verify, and respond to notices. The only piece most taxpayers ever see.

BACK OFFICE · TDS

TRACES – tdscpc.gov.in

Separate registration. Everything *after* a TDS statement is processed: Form 16/16A/16B downloads, corrections, defaults, Form 13 lower-deduction certificates.

DATA ENGINE

Compliance Portal – compliance.insight.gov.in

Project Insight. Hosts AIS/TIS, e-Campaign nudges, and e-Verification. You reach it from the e-Filing menu but it is a different application.

THIRD-PARTY FILINGS

Reporting Portal – report.insight.gov.in

For banks, registrars, exchanges. Form 61 / 61A (SFT) / 61B (FATCA-CRS) / 15CC. This is where the data in your AIS comes from.

The 2026 discontinuity. The Income-tax Act, 2025 replaced the 1961 Act on 1 April 2026, and the Income-tax Rules, 2026 renumbered nearly every form into one sequential series. "Assessment Year" and "Previous Year" collapse into a single **Tax Year**. Filings for AY 2026-27 and earlier still run on the old vocabulary and old form numbers, so the portal currently shows both. Old numbers are given throughout below, with new numbers where confirmed.

Registration and login

Six registration tracks

CATEGORY	KEY PREREQUISITES	USER ID / NOTES
Individual	Active PAN, working mobile, active email	PAN is the user ID. Instant activation.

CATEGORY	KEY PREREQUISITES	USER ID / NOTES
HUF	HUF's own PAN (4th char "H"); Karta's PAN as principal contact	Date of incorporation instead of DOB.
Company	Company PAN, CIN, principal contact's PAN already registered, valid DSC	DSC checked during registration itself.
Chartered Accountant	ICAI membership number + enrolment date, own PAN registered, active DSC	ARCA<membership no.>
TAN deductor/collector	Valid TAN; principal contact's PAN registered	Goes to a competent authority for activation — not instant.

Common to all: two separate 6-digit OTPs to mobile and email, each valid 15 minutes with 3 attempts. Password 8–14 characters with upper, lower, digit and special. You also set a **Secure Access Message** — the anti-phishing phrase shown back to you at every login.

Seven ways in

Password

PAN, Aadhaar or user ID
plus static password. The
default route.

Aadhaar OTP

OTP to the UIDAI-
registered mobile. Requires
PAN–Aadhaar linkage.

Net banking

Authenticate at your bank,
then click through to the
portal dashboard.

Bank / demat EVC

Account must be pre-
validated and EVC-enabled.
Code goes to the bank-
registered mobile.

DSC

emSigner utility plus USB
token. Mandatory for
companies and audit cases.

Static password

Pre-generated single-use
codes, for when you are
abroad without the Indian
SIM.

e-Filing Vault, higher security. You can force a second factor on login and on password reset independently — net banking, DSC, Aadhaar OTP, bank EVC or demat EVC. Worth knowing before you switch it on: once the vault is armed, the ordinary "forgot password" routes are disabled for that account and the helpdesk cannot bypass it. Lose the factor, lose the account.

Filing an income tax return

The portal's centre of gravity: e-File → Income Tax Returns → File Income Tax Return . You pick the year, the mode, your status, and the form – and a wizard will pick the form for you if you are unsure.

Which form applies

FORM	WHO FILES IT	HARD EXCLUSIONS
ITR-1 · Sahaj	Resident individual, income ≤ ₹50 lakh from salary/pension, house property, other sources; agricultural income ≤ ₹5,000; LTCG u/s 112A up to ₹1.25 lakh with no carried-forward loss	Non-resident, director, unlisted shares, foreign assets, other capital gains, brought-forward loss
ITR-2	Individuals and HUFs with no business income – capital gains, foreign assets, multiple properties, NR/RNOR, directorship	Any business or professional income
ITR-3	Individuals and HUFs with business or professional income; partners of firms; F&O and speculative income; audit cases	– (superset of ITR-2)
ITR-4 · Sugam	Resident individual/HUF/non-LLP firm, income ≤ ₹50 lakh under presumptive schemes 44AD, 44ADA, 44AE	Non-resident, director, unlisted shares, foreign assets
ITR-5	Firms, LLPs, AOPs, BOIs, business trusts, investment funds, co-operative societies, local authorities	–
ITR-6	Companies other than those claiming s.11 exemption	Must be filed with DSC
ITR-7	Trusts, charitable and religious institutions, political parties, research associations, universities	–

Changes flagged for AY 2026-27: two house properties permitted in ITR-1/4, a new unrealised-rent field, s.80G claims now need transaction reference and bank IFSC, s.80GGC needs the political party's name and PAN, and s.89A relief is removed from ITR-1/4.

Online mode – filling in the browser

- 1 Select assessment year (or tax year), filing status, and ITR form.

- 2 State the reason for filing — this is where you flag original, revised, belated, or a s.119(2)(b) condonation filing.
- 3 Work through the prefilled sections: Personal Info, Gross Total Income, Deductions, Tax Paid, Total Tax Liability. Every prefilled figure is editable and remains your responsibility.
- 4 Preview the return, then *Proceed to Validation*.
- 5 Pay any balance self-assessment tax through e-Pay Tax and enter the challan details.
- 6 *Proceed to Verification* — and verify within 30 days.

Offline mode — the JSON and Excel utilities

Download the **Common Offline Utility** (covers ITR-1 to 4, Windows and macOS) or a form-specific utility from Downloads . Import the prefill JSON, fill the tabs, validate, generate JSON — then return to the portal and attach it. The utility itself cannot upload.

Excel utilities, reintroduced from AY 2025-26 for the heavier forms, need Microsoft Excel 2016 or later with macros enabled — which means no Mac Excel edge cases, no Linux, no ChromeOS, no mobile. For ITR-3 and ITR-5 filers this is a real platform constraint, not a footnote.

Original, belated, revised, updated

TYPE	WINDOW FOR AY 2026-27	COST
Original	31 Jul 2026 (ITR-1/2) · 31 Aug 2026 (non-audit ITR-3/4) · 31 Oct (audit) · 30 Nov (transfer pricing)	None
Belated s.139(4)	Up to 31 Dec 2026	₹1,000 fee if income ≤ ₹5 lakh, else ₹5,000, plus 1%/month interest. Business, capital and speculation losses can no longer be carried forward.
Revised s.139(5)	Any number of times, to 31 Dec 2026 (some sources read 31 Mar 2027 — verify)	None

TYPE

WINDOW FOR AY 2026-27

COST

ITR-U cannot rescue a refund. It cannot reduce liability, claim or increase a refund, or declare a loss — and it is barred where search, survey or prosecution proceedings are pending. If a refund is what you missed, the route is condonation of delay under s.119(2)(b), not an updated return.

Under the Income-tax Act, 2025 all of this consolidates into **Section 263**: belated within 9 months of the tax year end, revised within 12 months, updated returns at s.263(6) keeping the 48-month ladder.

e-Verification — the step that invalidates returns

Filing is not filing until it is verified. Since 1 August 2022 the window is **30 days** from transmission.

93.6%

of e-verifications done by
Aadhaar OTP (AY 2024-25:
5.81 cr of 6.21 cr)

6

available methods — Aadhaar
OTP, bank EVC, demat EVC,
net banking, ATM, DSC

72 hrs

EVC validity, single use, one
code per item verified

How the 30-day rule bites

- Verified **within** 30 days → the date of filing is the date you transmitted. Everything is normal.
- Verified **after** 30 days → the date of verification becomes the date of filing. A return that was on time becomes belated, with late fee, interest, and loss of carry-forward.
- Never verified → treated as never filed.

The physical fallback still exists: print the ITR-V, sign in blue ink, and send it by **ordinary post or Speed Post only** — no courier, no registered post — to *Centralised Processing Centre, Income Tax Department, Bengaluru 560500*. It must *reach* CPC within the same 30 days. The PDF password is your PAN in lowercase followed by date of birth as DDMMYYYY.

A single point of failure. With 94% of verification running through Aadhaar OTP, a UIDAI outage during the July peak would stall verification for almost the entire filing base. There is no capacity in the alternatives to absorb that load.

Form 26AS, AIS and TIS

Three statements, in a chain. Reporting entities file data → AIS shows it raw → TIS aggregates it → your return is prefilled from TIS.

THE TAX-CREDIT DOCUMENT

Form 26AS NOW FORM 168

Generated by TRACES, not by the e-Filing portal — the menu item just redirects you there with the session carried across. Parts A to H: TDS, TCS, other tax paid, refunds, SFT, TDS on property, TDS defaults, GSTR-3B turnover. PDF password is date of birth as DDMMYYYY.

It is no longer the prefill source, but it remains the authoritative document for *claiming* TDS. And crucially: a 26AS error can only be fixed by the **deductor** filing a correction statement. You cannot fix your own 26AS.

THE FULL PICTURE

Annual Information Statement

Part A is identity. Part B carries TDS/TCS, SFT (cash deposits, credit card spends, securities and mutual fund trades, property, foreign remittance, dividend, interest), tax payments, demand and refund, and "Other Information" — Form 15CC remittances, GST turnover, off-market trades, FATCA/CRS foreign data.

AIS deliberately shows duplicates. TIS de-duplicates them. Download as PDF, JSON or CSV; password is PAN in lowercase plus DOB as DDMMYYYY.

The feedback loop — and why it matters

Each AIS line takes feedback: *information is correct*, *not fully correct* (with a corrected value), *relates to other PAN or year*, *duplicate*, *denied*, or a category-specific custom option.

Submitting it regenerates TIS in real time, and the **derived value in TIS is what flows into your prefill**. That is the whole mechanism — feedback is not a complaint box, it is the only user-facing control on prefilled data.

You get an acknowledgement receipt, an activity history, and both the reported and modified values shown side by side. There is no limit on revisions. A consolidated feedback file collects everything other than "correct" for review before filing.

AIS for Taxpayer — the department's only mobile app, launched March 2023 (Android and iOS). PAN login, OTP, then a 4-digit PIN. It views AIS and TIS and accepts feedback. It cannot file anything.

e-Campaign nudges

The Compliance Portal pushes campaigns at taxpayers: **significant transactions** inconsistent with the return filed, **non-filing** of return, **high-value transactions**, and an **advance tax** nudge before the 15 March instalment. You respond per transaction with the same option set as AIS feedback. An unsatisfactory response escalates into the e-Verification Scheme, where you may be asked to file an updated return.

CBDT's **NUDGE** campaign, running since December 2025, reports 1.11 crore taxpayers prompted into corrections and ₹8,800 crore in additional tax over two years.

e-Pay Tax

Successor to the old OLTAS/NSDL challan system. Every payment starts as a **CRN** – a pre-payment token carrying PAN or TAN, the year, the heads, and the tax break-up.

15 days

CRN validity; +90 days if a cheque or DD is presented at a bank counter within it

5

payment modes — net banking, debit card, bank counter, NEFT/RTGS, payment gateway

₹10,000

cash cap per challan at a bank counter

Payment modes compared

MODE	COVERS	CHARGES	CONSTRAINT
Net banking	Authorised banks only	Nil	~33 authorised banks as at April 2026
Debit card	Canara, ICICI, Indian Bank, SBI, PNB, Union Bank	Nil	Very limited issuer set
Bank counter	Cash, cheque, DD	Nil	Not available to companies or audit-liable persons — e-payment is mandatory for them
NEFT / RTGS	Any bank, any branch	Your bank's transfer charges	The fallback when your bank is not authorised. Credit is not instant
Payment gateway	Net banking, debit card, credit card, UPI	Nil for UPI up to ~2.75% + GST on	The only route for credit card and UPI

MODE

COVERS

CHARGES

CONSTRAINT

Heads, and where people go wrong

Major head 0020 for corporation tax, 0021 for everyone else. **Minor head** is where errors happen: 100 advance tax · 300 self-assessment tax · 400 tax on regular assessment (paying a demand) · 800 TDS on property, rent, 194M and 194S. Deductors on a TAN login use 200 for regular TDS remittance and 400 for CPC-TDS demands.

A CRN **cannot be modified** once generated — not the year, not the head, not the mode. Wrong details means generating a fresh CRN and letting the old one expire. The single most common taxpayer error is paying advance tax against the wrong assessment year, and it is not fixable at the point of payment.

On success you get a **Challan Receipt** carrying the CIN — BSR code, date of deposit, and challan serial. That triple is what you enter in the return's taxes-paid schedule. Prefill usually picks the challan up within 3–5 working days. Services → Challan Correction can fix assessment year, major head and minor head within limits; beyond that you apply to your Assessing Officer.

Worth knowing: under the 1961-Act track a challan carried one section code. From TY 2026-27, one challan can carry up to 20 — a genuine operational simplification for deductors.

The statutory forms menu

Everything at e-File → Income Tax Forms . Three filing patterns exist, and knowing which one a form uses saves a lot of hunting.

PATTERN 1

Fully online

Fill in the browser, e-verify. Forms 10E, 10-IEA, 10A/10AB, 15CA, 35, 67, and the 26Q-series.

PATTERN 2

Offline JSON utility

Download, fill, generate JSON, upload, sign. Most audit and accountant forms.

PATTERN 3

CA assignment workflow

A four-hop handshake between taxpayer and chartered accountant. Every form needing an accountant's certificate.

The CA assignment workflow, step by step

- 1

Taxpayer adds the CA at `Authorised Partners` → `My Chartered Accountant` using the ICAI membership number. This is a standing relationship, separate from any one form.
- 2

Taxpayer assigns the specific form and year to that CA, attaches supporting documents, and e-verifies the assignment.
- 3

CA sees it under `Pending Actions` → `Worklist` → `For Your Action` and accepts — or rejects with a reason.
- 4

CA downloads the offline utility, fills the form, attaches the balance sheet, P&L and annexures as PDFs, generates JSON, uploads, and signs **with the CA's own DSC**. Aadhaar OTP and EVC are not accepted for audit forms.
- 5

The form returns to the taxpayer's worklist. **The taxpayer must accept it, with DSC, for the form to count as filed.** Rejection sends it back.

A CA added this way can file assigned statutory forms and audit reports. They *cannot* file your ITR in that capacity — filing returns on someone's behalf requires ERI status or authorised-representative registration. This distinction trips up a lot of first-time users.

Form by form

OLD	NEW	PURPOSE	FILED BY / HOW
10E	39	Relief u/s 89 on salary arrears, gratuity, commuted pension, termination compensation	Taxpayer, online. Must precede the ITR — CPC disallows the relief if 10E is missing
10-IEA	–	Opting out of the default new regime (business and professional income only)	Taxpayer, online, by the s.139(1) due date. One lifetime opt-out plus one re-entry
10A / 10AB	104 / 105	Trust and NPO registration — provisional (10A) and regular/renewal (10AB)	Online with trustee's DSC. Order issues in Form 10AC
10B / 10BB	112	Audit report for a registered trust or NPO	CA workflow, offline utility, due one month before the ITR

OLD	NEW	PURPOSE	FILED BY / HOW
15CA	145	Information on a remittance to a non-resident. Parts A–D by amount and taxability	Remitter, online. Withdrawable within 7 days
15CB	146	CA certificate on taxability, rate, TDS and treaty position for that remittance	CA workflow with DSC. Must be filed <i>before</i> 15CA Part C
15G / 15H	121	Self-declaration for nil TDS — 15G under 60, 15H for 60+	Given to the payer; the deductor uploads the consolidated quarterly statement
35	99	First appeal to CIT(A) or JCIT(A)	Online only. 30 days from the demand notice
3CA-3CD 3CB-3CD	26	Tax audit u/s 44AB. 3CA where accounts are already audited under another law, 3CB where not; 3CD is the ~44-clause particulars statement	CA workflow, DSC mandatory both sides. Consolidated into one Form 26 from 2026
3CEB	48	Accountant's report on international and specified domestic transactions (transfer pricing)	CA workflow, due 31 October
67	44	Foreign tax credit claim with country-wise income and tax paid	Taxpayer, online, with proof of foreign tax paid
26QB/QC/QD/QE	141	Challan-cum-statement for non-TAN TDS — property, rent, contractor payments, virtual digital assets	Filed on PAN. See below
49A / 49AA	93–96	PAN application, Indian and foreign	Via Protean or UTIITSL —

Also here: 10-IB/IC/ID (concessional corporate rates), 29B/29C (MAT and AMT), 10CCB, 10BD/10BE (donation statement and certificate), the 3CEAA–3CEAD Master File and CbCR set, 64/64A-E for business trusts and AIFs, 10F and 10FA for treaty relief and tax residency certificates, and 3CEC/3CED for advance pricing agreements.

Deductors, collectors and TDS

The e-Filing / TRACES split

One sentence covers the division of labour: **e-Filing is where you pay the challan and upload the statement; TRACES is everything after the statement is processed.**

ON E-FILING (TAN LOGIN)

- e-Pay Tax for TAN challans
- Quarterly statements 24Q, 26Q, 27Q, 27EQ — upload the FVU-validated ZIP, verify by DSC or EVC
- Consolidated Form 15G/15H upload
- Form 27C, Form 15CC, Form 24G
- Outstanding demand

ON TRACES ONLY

- Download Form 16, 16A, 27D — and 16B/16C/16D/16E
- Justification report and consolidated file
- Online corrections: PAN, challan movement, deductee rows
- Defaults and demand
- Form 13 lower-deduction certificates

Statements are due 31 July, 31 October, 31 January and 31 May. Form 16 by 15 June; 16A and 27D within 15 days of the statement due date. Late filing costs ₹200 a day under s.234E. The Return Preparation Utility and File Validation Utility come from Protean, not from incometax.gov.in.

The 26QB family — TDS without a TAN

FORM	TRIGGER	RATE	CERTIFICATE
26QB	Purchase of immovable property where consideration <i>or</i> stamp duty value $\geq$ ₹50 lakh	1%	16B
26QC	Rent above ₹50,000/month paid by an individual or HUF not under audit	2%	16C
26QD	Contractual, professional or commission payments above ₹50 lakh a year by a non-audit individual or HUF	2%	16D
26QE	Transfer of virtual digital assets by a specified person	1%	16E

Filed on PAN, no TAN needed, within **30 days from the end of the month** of deduction. The certificate is downloaded from TRACES after ~5–7 working days of processing and must be issued to the payee within 15 days.

Two failure modes worth naming. First: a separate 26QB is required for *every buyer–seller pair* — two buyers and two sellers means four forms, each for its proportionate share. This is the most common property-TDS mistake. Second: if the seller is a **non-resident**, 26QB does

not apply at all. Section 195 does, the buyer must obtain a TAN, and file 27Q. Getting this wrong is expensive and not quietly fixable.

Refunds

Getting the bank account right, first

At My Profile → My Bank Account you add and pre-validate accounts, nominate one for refund, enable EVC on it, revalidate failed ones, and nominate one for net-banking login. Validation runs in real time against the bank: the **name must match the PAN name** and the **PAN must be linked in the bank's own records**. Only savings, current, cash credit, overdraft and NRO accounts can be nominated.

Typical validation failures: PAN not linked at the bank, name mismatch, dormant or closed account, and — very common in 2026 — a stale IFSC after a bank merger.

Refund reissue when it fails

- 1 Services → Refund Reissue → Create Refund Reissue Request
- 2 Select the failed refund record and continue.
- 3 Choose the destination account — only pre-validated accounts appear, so add one first if needed.
- 4 e-Verify the request by Aadhaar OTP, DSC or EVC. A transaction ID is issued.

No fee, no limit on the number of requests.

Why refunds actually stall

- **CPC backlog** at record filing volumes — of 8.82 crore returns filed for AY 2025-26, 8.17 crore were processed, leaving a substantial tail into 2026.
- **Data mismatch** between the return and 26AS/AIS/TIS, triggering a verification hold.
- **Enhanced scrutiny of large refund claims** — a deliberate policy shift from 2025-26, with manual review of unusually high claims.
- **NUDGE holds** pending clarification on potentially ineligible deductions.
- **Bank pre-validation failure** — the leading cause of an outright "refund failed".

- **Section 245 set-off** against an old outstanding demand, often one the taxpayer disputes or never received notice of.
- **Unverified return** — filed but never e-verified.

Interest under s.244A accrues at 0.5% a month on delayed refunds where the refund exceeds 10% of the tax determined. The department has until 31 December 2026 to process FY 2024-25 returns.

Corrections and relief

SERVICES → RECTIFICATION

Section 154 rectification

Prerequisite: an intimation u/s 143(1) must already have been received. You cannot rectify a return that has not been processed.

Request types: reprocess the return · tax credit mismatch correction · additional information for 234C interest · status correction (ITR-5/7) · exemption section correction (ITR-7) · return data correction, online or by uploading corrected JSON.

Scope limit: only a "mistake apparent from the record" — arithmetic, tax credits, wrong rate. Not a way to revise figures you have changed your mind about. Time limit is 4 years from the end of the financial year of the order; CPC should dispose within 6 months.

If the case shows "transferred to AO", the online option disappears and you must apply to the officer directly.

SERVICES → CONDONATION REQUEST

Section 119(2)(b) condonation

Two types: delay in submitting ITR-V, and — the substantive one — delay in filing a return that claims a refund or carry-forward of loss.

Governed by CBDT Circular 11/2024. Apply **within 5 years** of the assessment year's end. Authority by claim size: up to ₹1 crore with the Principal Commissioner, ₹1–3 crore at Chief Commissioner level, above ₹3 crore with the Principal CCIT. Disposal target is six months.

After approval, file using the **offline utility only**, selecting "return filed in response to condonation order u/s 119(2)(b)" and entering the order date and DIN.

Why this beats ITR-U for a missed refund: where condonation is granted, no additional tax, interest or penalty is payable — and unlike ITR-U, a refund can actually be claimed.

Notices, proceedings and demands

e-Proceedings — the single notice interface

Everything from CPC and from assessing officers lands here, including the faceless schemes: defective return notices u/s 139(9), prima facie adjustment communications u/s 143(1)(a), suo-moto rectification, faceless assessment under s.144B, reassessment under 148/148A, and penalty proceedings.

RESPONSE MECHANICS

- Free text up to 4,000 characters; attachments up to 5 MB per file
- Prima facie adjustments are answered **item by item**, agreeing or disagreeing with each variance
- Defective returns: agree and upload a corrected JSON, or disagree with written justification
- Partial responses can be submitted in stages before a final submission closes the item

OPTIONS MANY USERS MISS

- Request an **adjournment** of the response deadline
- Request a **video conference** with the officer — under s.144B this goes to the National Faceless Assessment Centre
- An authorised representative can respond on your behalf, with an OTP step

Response to outstanding demand

At Pending Actions → Response to Outstanding Demand you either agree and pay, or disagree in full or in part — choosing from a reason list (already paid, reduced by rectification, reduced by an appellate order, appeal filed with stay pending, revised return filed) or writing your own. Where you partly disagree, pay the accepted portion and dispute the balance.

Silence is consent. The portal states it plainly: if you do not respond, "the demand will be confirmed and will be adjusted against your refund (if any)". The s.245 intimation carries a 30-day window, and after it CPC proceeds with the set-off.

Authenticate a notice before you act on it

A pre-login service, and a genuinely important one. Enter either PAN plus document type, year and date of issuance, or simply the **DIN**. Since CBDT Circular 19/2019, any communication without a valid verifiable DIN is **deemed never to have been issued**. This is the taxpayer's defence against a forged notice — and the field now offers "Tax Year" alongside "Assessment Year", one of the first visible traces of the 2025 Act in the UI.

Appeals and dispute resolution

FORM 35 • ONLINE ONLY

First appeal to CIT(A) / JCIT(A)

30 days from the notice of demand. Fees scale with assessed income: ₹250 up to ₹1 lakh, ₹500 to ₹2 lakh, ₹1,000 above — and ₹250 for any other subject.

Tabs cover basic information, the order appealed against, pending appeals, statement of facts and grounds, taxes paid, and appeal fee. Attachments: 5 MB per file, 50 MB total, PDF or ZIP only. Late filing needs a condonation ground stated in the form. Conducted under the Faceless Appeal Scheme 2020 and e-Appeals Scheme 2023, with personal hearing by video conference on request.

FORM 34BC • S.245MA

e-Dispute Resolution — small cases

The live alternative to appeal for small disputes. **Variation ≤ ₹10 lakh and returned income ≤ ₹50 lakh.** Fee ₹1,000, online only, within one month of the order.

Covers draft orders u/s 144C, intimations u/s 143(1), assessments and reassessments, s.154 orders, and TDS/TCS intimations. Excluded: anything arising from a search, survey, or information under an international agreement — and applicants with specified convictions or pending prosecution. The committee must decide within six months of admission.

FORM 35A • S.144C

Dispute Resolution Panel

For "eligible assesseees" — any case with a transfer pricing adjustment, and any non-resident or foreign company — objecting to a **draft** assessment order. 30 days, filed simultaneously to the DRP and the AO. The panel must direct within 9 months; its directions bind the officer.

CLOSED

Vivad se Vishwas 2024

Opened 1 October 2024; concessional rate ended 31 December 2024; final declarations 31 January 2025. Forms 1 to 4 remain documented on the portal for reference but **there is no live filing window in 2026** and no successor scheme announced.

Utility services

Pre-login, no account needed

SERVICE	WHAT IT DOES	INPUTS
Instant e-PAN	Free digitally-signed PAN. Not for anyone who already holds a PAN, is a minor, or is a representative assessee	Aadhaar + linked mobile + DigiLocker consent for a date-of-birth proof
Link Aadhaar / status	PAN–Aadhaar linkage. ₹1,000 fee u/s 234H for late linking, paid under minor head 500 first	PAN, Aadhaar
Verify your PAN	Confirms name, DOB and whether the PAN is active	PAN, name, DOB, any mobile. Capped at 5 PANs per mobile per day
Know your JAO	Your jurisdictional officer — area code, AO type, range, address, email	PAN + mobile OTP
Know TAN details	Cross-check a deductor's TAN against Form 16/16A/26AS	TAN, or name and state
Verify service request	Confirm a request an ERI submitted for you — client addition, form filing, refund reissue, rectification, contact changes	PAN + transaction ID. Lapses in 7 days
Authenticate notice/order	Confirms a communication genuinely came from the department	DIN, or PAN with document type, year and issue date
ITR status	Return lifecycle status without logging in	Acknowledgement number + mobile OTP
Tax calculator	Old versus new regime comparison for the selected year	Income details
Tax evasion / benami petition	Report evasion, benami property, or undisclosed foreign assets. Can be anonymous — though the informant reward schemes require identification	OTP; returns a complaint number for tracking

Inoperative PAN. If Aadhaar is not linked, the PAN goes inoperative — no refund is issued, no interest accrues on it, and TDS/TCS applies at the higher rates under 206AA/206CC. Residents of Assam, J&K and Meghalaya, non-residents, anyone 80 or above, and non-citizens are exempt from linking. PANs obtained using an Aadhaar enrolment ID had until 31 December 2025 and went inoperative from 1 January 2026.

Generate EVC

A 10-digit code, valid **72 hours, single use** — a separate EVC for each item verified. Generated through net banking, a bank ATM, a pre-validated bank account, or a pre-validated demat account. The PAN must be linked to the account used. **Companies cannot verify by EVC at all** and must use DSC.

Two services that are effectively historical

Compliance check for 206AB / 206CCA

GONE

Sections 206AB and 206CCA — higher TDS/TCS for non-filers — were **omitted by the Finance Act 2025 with effect from 1 April 2025**. Deductors no longer need to run non-filer checks. The compliance check for s.194N (cash withdrawals) remains live and separate.

Tax Return Preparer scheme DORMANT

Notified in 2006 under s.139B to help small taxpayers, run through trpscheme.com. The scheme site's content is largely a decade stale and there is no evidence of meaningful 2026 activity. The portal's Assisted Filing pages are the current channel.

Profile, partners and representatives

DASHBOARD

What it shows you

- Filing status against due dates, refund and demand amounts
- A return-lifecycle progress graph and three years of filing history
- The last four forms filed and a rolling 90-day activity log
- Aadhaar linkage status and an account security level driven by your vault settings
- Grievance tracking for two years, and any Certificate of Appreciation

REGISTER DSC

The emSigner dependency

Needs the DSC Management Utility installed from Downloads, plus a USB token from a licensed Certifying Authority carrying a Class 2 or Class 3 certificate. Register at [My Profile](#) → Register DSC : select provider and certificate, enter the provider password, sign. Expired certificates must be re-registered through the same flow.

Representatives, signatories and legal heirs

Three distinct routes at [Authorised Partners](#) and [My Profile](#) :

- **Register as Representative** — apply to act for another assessee. This is also the **legal heir** route for a deceased person's returns. Recognised categories: deceased, minor, mentally incapacitated, court of wards or official trustee, and non-resident agent.
- **Register on behalf of another person** — you register yourself to act for someone who authorises you.
- **Add authorised signatory** — the assessee designates a signatory, giving a reason such as absence from the country or non-resident status.

Both parties need active PANs and portal registrations. Requests are processed within 7 days. Supporting documents up to 5 MB per file or 50 MB zipped. The signatory must accept or reject within 7 days, supplying a **notarised power of attorney** or rejection comments. Legal heir registration typically needs the death certificate, both PANs, and legal heir proof — a registered will, succession certificate, court order, or notarised surviving-member affidavit.

Managing your CA

Add by membership number; the CA must accept before any form can be assigned. From there you can assign forms by name, year and filing type, extend a CA's validity, deactivate one (a reason is required), reactivate with a new validity period, and withdraw already-assigned forms. Every action generates a transaction ID.

Grievances and support

e-Nivaran

Open to registered and unregistered users. Choose the target department — **e-Filing** for portal and technical issues, **Assessing Officer** for demands, appeals and PAN, **CPC-ITR** for processing, refunds and ITR-V, **CPC-TDS** for TDS refunds, challans and quarterly statements — then describe the issue in at least 100 characters, with optional attachments. Track pre-login with the acknowledgement number and mobile, or post-login on the grievance dashboard.

28 days

average CPGRAMS resolution
in FY 2025-26, down from 57
· 94% of ~78,000 disposed

42 days

average e-Nivaran disposal ·
95% of ~3.5 lakh grievances
resolved

10.64 L

helpdesk queries handled in
the AY 2024-25 season alone

There is no documented escalation ladder beyond e-Nivaran. In practice: reopen the grievance, then CPGRAMS at pgportal.gov.in. The Income Tax Ombudsman was abolished in 2019 and is no longer a route.

Helplines

SERVICE	NUMBERS	HOURS
e-Filing and CPC	1800 103 0025 · 1800 419 0025 · +91-80-46122000	08:00–20:00, Mon–Fri only
Tax Information Network	+91-20-27218080	07:00–23:00, all days
AIS and Reporting Portal	1800 103 4215	09:30–18:00, Mon–Fri
e-Pay Tax	epay.helpdesk@incometax.gov.in	—

Kar Saathi, launched 2 April 2026, is the portal's AI assistant — real-time answers across 2,000+ topics spanning filing, challans, verification, refunds, notices and compliance, with step-by-step ITR guidance in Hindi and English. **Co-browsing** also remains available, letting a helpdesk agent see and guide your session with consent.

Who uses it, and how many

CBDT publishes filing volumes generously and registration counts almost never. Everything below is sourced; where no number exists, that is said rather than estimated.

12.13 cr

total taxpayers for AY 2024-25 — filed a return or had TDS deducted

9.18 cr

returns filed in FY 2024-25, all types — up ~35% in five years

~58 L

first-time filers onboarding every season

Returns filed, by assessment year

AY	FILED BY THE DEADLINE	DEADLINE	PEAK SINGLE DAY
2022-23	5.83 crore	31 Jul 2022	72.4 lakh
2023-24	6.77 crore +16.1%	31 Jul 2023	64.33 lakh
2024-25	7.28 crore +7.5%	31 Jul 2024	69.92 lakh

AY	FILED BY THE DEADLINE	DEADLINE	PEAK SINGLE DAY
2025-26	7.3 crore+	16 Sep 2025 EXTENDED	not published

Read the AY 2026-27 number carefully. 5.9 crore against 7.3 crore looks like collapse, but AY 2025-26 had a 47-day extension and AY 2026-27 had none. The honest comparison is 5.9 crore on 31 July 2026 against 7.28 crore on 31 July 2024 — still a softening, plausibly because the ₹12 lakh nil-tax threshold removed the filing incentive for a slice of the base. CBDT has not explained the gap. Final totals will rise through the 31 December belated window.

What peak load looks like

917

ITRs per second — peak, 17 July 2024 at 08:13

5.07 L

ITRs in the peak hour, 31 July 2024, 19:00–20:00

3.2 cr

successful logins on deadline day 2024

The load is getting spikier faster than it is getting bigger: between AY 2023-24 and AY 2024-25, daily volume rose 9% while the per-second peak nearly doubled, from 486 to 917. By July 2026 the department reported handling **83.8 lakh to 1.22 crore ITRs per day** during 8–14 July, against 31.8–42.6 lakh a day in 2025, with validated capacity at 1 crore returns a day.

Who files what

Form mix, AY 2024-25 (7.28 crore returns)

ITR-1 · Sahaj	45.8%
ITR-4 · Sugam	25.8%
ITR-2	14.9%
ITR-3	12.5%
ITR-5 / 6 / 7	1.0%

Roughly **72% of all returns are ITR-1 plus ITR-4** — salaried people with straightforward income, and small presumptive-scheme businesspeople. The entire non-individual universe, every company, LLP, firm and trust in India, is about 1% of return volume while carrying most of the revenue.

The movement worth watching is **ITR-2, up 34% in a single year** (81 lakh → 1.09 crore, 11.97% → 14.93%). That is retail equity and mutual fund participation pushing salaried filers out of ITR-1 and into capital-gains territory — a structural shift toward more complex returns from people who were previously one-page filers.

ITR-5/6/7 shares look artificially small in a July snapshot because audited entities file in October and November. The true annual counts are around 18 lakh firms, 12 lakh companies, 13.8 lakh HUFs and 3.4 lakh trusts.

Taxpayer composition, AY 2024-25

CATEGORY	COUNT	PORTAL FOOTPRINT
Individuals	11,61,36,768	The portal's mass user base. ITR-1 through ITR-4
Companies	11,97,412	DSC-mandatory, ITR-6, tax audit, TDS returns. The heaviest per-user load
Firms	18,06,205	ITR-5, mostly CA-mediated
HUFs	13,76,723	Karta verifies, usually by DSC or Aadhaar OTP
Trusts / AOP	3,40,401	ITR-7, plus Forms 10A/10AB/10B and the donation statements

Segmenting the user base

Five distinct populations use this portal, with almost nothing in common between the extremes — different frequency, different features, different failure modes.

~46% OF RETURNS · ONCE A YEAR

The salaried once-a-year filer

Uses: ITR-1 online, prefill, Aadhaar OTP verification, refund status, AIS view. That is essentially the whole feature set.

Shows up: June–July, once. Maybe again in autumn to chase a refund.

Breaks on: AIS mismatches they cannot fix, prefill errors, forgotten verification inside 30

~26% OF RETURNS · ONCE A YEAR

The small presumptive business

Uses: ITR-4, advance tax challans, sometimes 26QB or 26QC as a payer. Frequently mediated by a local consultant rather than filing directly.

Shows up: filing season plus four advance-tax dates.

days, failed bank pre-validation.

Breaks on: wrong assessment year on a challan, Form 10-IEA regime elections, the digital divide — this segment is most likely to be filing through an intermediary on a shared machine.

~27% OF RETURNS • SEVERAL TIMES A YEAR

The investor and the complex individual

Uses: ITR-2 or ITR-3, offline Excel or JSON utilities, AIS feedback, Form 67 for foreign tax credit, Schedule FA, rectification requests.

Shows up: filing season, advance tax dates, plus AIS reconciliation through the year.

Breaks on: late utility releases, mid-season schema changes, capital gains data mis-tagged from demat feeds, the s.87A rebate class of software-generated demands.

~1% OF RETURNS • CONTINUOUSLY

Corporates and audited entities

Uses: nearly everything — ITR-6, tax audit forms, 3CEB, quarterly TDS statements on a separate TAN login, TRACES corrections, e-Proceedings, appeals, DSC on every action.

Shows up: monthly (TDS challans), quarterly (TDS returns), and through a long autumn audit season.

Breaks on: DSC and emSigner failures, TRACES outages, audit-form utility bugs, deadline collisions.

THE POWER USERS

Chartered accountants and ERIs

CAs work the portal daily through the assignment and worklist system, switching between dozens of client profiles. ERIs — ClearTax, Tax2win, Quicko, TaxBuddy and peers — file through APIs at volume. Neither population's size is published; ICAI's ~4 lakh members and ~1.5 lakh practising CAs is only a ceiling.

Breaks on: forced logout when switching client profiles, OTP delays causing session timeouts on long audit forms, DSC registration errors, saved form data vanishing mid-submission. These are the complaints ICAI formally escalated to CBDT.

THE INVISIBLE SEGMENT

Two-thirds owe nothing

66.5% of filers had zero tax liability in FY 2024-25 — 5.58 crore of 8.39 crore — up from 44.75% in 2019-20. They file to reclaim TDS, to satisfy a mandatory filing trigger, or because a lender or visa office asked for the return.

This reframes what the portal is. For most of its users it is not a tax payment system at all. It is a **refund and documentation system** — which is exactly why refund delays generate the volume of grievance they do.

Where filers are

Maharashtra	1.40 cr
Uttar Pradesh	91.7 L
Gujarat	88.8 L
Rajasthan	60.8 L
Tamil Nadu	56.9 L
West Bengal	56.0 L
Karnataka	53.7 L
Delhi	44.6 L
Punjab	43.1 L
Madhya Pradesh	37.7 L

Top ten states are ~73% of all filings. Note the divergence between filings and collections: Maharashtra and Karnataka dominate direct tax *revenue* far more than they dominate filer *counts*, because corporate headquarters cluster there. UP has gained tax-base share faster than any other state.

Gender: 2.29 crore women filed for AY 2023-24, up 25.3% in four years — roughly 28–29% of the filing base. Top states: Maharashtra 36.8 lakh, Gujarat 22.5 lakh, UP 20.4 lakh. **Age:** the department holds it in every PAN record and has never published it.

The regime flip

72%

chose the new regime in AY 2024-25 — 5.27 crore filers

88%

by FY 2025-26, per the CBDT Chairman — which is itself now shrinking refund volumes, since fewer deductions means less excess TDS

How often people show up

One of the most extreme-seasonality consumer systems anywhere: a ~900-per-second peak against a near-idle baseline for much of the year.

Apr–May **Trough.** Form 16 not yet issued, AIS not yet populated, utilities often not yet released. The recurring complaint season for professionals, not the traffic season.

15 Jun	First advance tax instalment (15%) and Form 16 issuance deadline. AIS and TIS populate. Filing begins in earnest.
July	The rush. 32 crore logins in July 2023 alone. 1.22 crore ITRs in a single day by July 2026. Load compounds daily through the month.
31 Jul	Deadline day — and a collision. ~10% of the entire year's individual filings land in 24 hours, evening-weighted (peak hour 19:00–20:00, an after-work pattern). The quarterly TDS statement deadline falls the same day , so a completely different user population hits the same infrastructure simultaneously.
31 Aug	New from AY 2026-27: staggered statutory deadline for non-audit ITR-3 and ITR-4 — the Finance Act 2026's direct answer to peak concentration.
15 Sep	Second advance tax instalment (45% cumulative).
Sep–Nov	The second wave. Tax audit reports (30 Sep), audit-case returns (31 Oct), transfer pricing (30 Nov). ITR-5/6/7 volume lands here, almost entirely CA-mediated. Also the season of extension litigation.
15 Dec	Third advance tax instalment (75% cumulative).
31 Dec	Belated and revised return cutoff — a real secondary spike, 15–19 lakh a day in comparable cycles.
15 Mar	Final advance tax instalment (100%), preceded by CBDT's advance tax e-campaign nudge.
Jan–Mar	Processing and refund tail. ITR-U filings trickle in across a four-year window.

Layered continuously underneath: monthly TDS challan remittances (1.26 crore challans in July 2023 alone), quarterly TDS statements on 31 Jul / 31 Oct / 31 Jan / 31 May, and processing throughput of 2–7 lakh returns a day during active periods.

What goes wrong

The origin story still shapes the present

IEC 2.0 was awarded to Infosys in January 2019 at an approved cost of **₹4,241.97 crore**, and went live on 7 June 2021. It failed immediately — logins broken, utilities missing, DSC

registration dead, prior returns inaccessible, whole-day outages. On **23 August 2021** the Finance Minister summoned the Infosys CEO and set a hard deadline of 15 September to fix it. CBDT's Circular 17/2021 stated the reason for that year's extensions in the department's own words: portal functionalities "not yet upto mark" and "technical glitches not yet resolved". AY 2021-22 non-audit returns slipped from 31 July to **31 December 2021**.

The complaint set, 2025–26

The most authoritative catalogue is ICAI's Direct Taxes Committee representation to CBDT of 23–24 September 2025, built on responses from **1,200+ members**:

ACCESS AND SESSION

- Login authentication failures at peak
- OTP delays causing session timeouts mid-form
- Forced logout when switching between client profiles — a CA-specific killer
- DSC registration errors and emSigner problems
- The opaque `Something went wrong`

DATA AND FORMS

- "Service Unavailable" on AIS, TIS and Form 26AS
- Challan generation delays *after* successful payment
- Form 10AB saved data vanishing mid-submission
- Prefill errors: wrong employer TAN, dividends against the wrong PAN, capital gains mis-tagged
- Excel utility defects — ITR-1 AY 2026-27 v1.0 threw a VBA run-time type mismatch

ICAI's damning datapoint: at the point of that September 2025 representation, only **3,77,243 tax audit reports** had been filed — roughly **10% of the prior year's level at the same date**. That is not user reluctance. That is a system not letting people file.

The utility release problem, which recurs annually

Forms are notified in spring; the utilities and JSON schemas that let anyone actually use them arrive months later. ITR-2 and ITR-3 utilities landed in July 2025; ITR-5/6/7 in August — compressing a nominally four-month window into weeks. KSCAA wrote to the CBDT Chairman on **11 May 2026** making the same point for AY 2026-27: forms notified, utilities and schemas still unavailable. Their asks were precise — release everything including the 3CA/3CB, 10B/10BB and 10-IE/10-IEA utilities, assure post-rollout stability, and **minimise post-release revisions**, because each mid-season schema change invalidates work already done.

Software generating demands the law does not support

The clearest case is the **s.87A rebate episode**. Before 5 July 2024, the ITR utility allowed the rebate against special-rate income. After a silent utility change that day, it disallowed it. The Bombay High Court, in *The Chamber of Tax Consultants v. UoI* (24 December 2024), found the software itself was denying eligible taxpayers a statutory rebate, and ordered a revision window — which CBDT opened for 1–15 January 2025.

Then from around April 2025, demand notices under s.143(1) went out to sub-₹7-lakh taxpayers who had revised — **including those who had filed before 5 July 2024 and been correctly granted the rebate in the first place**. The recourse offered was rectification, grievance, or appeal: cost and delay pushed onto the taxpayer for a defect that was never theirs.

A related pattern in March 2026: advance tax e-campaign emails listed "significant transactions" recipients had never conducted. The department publicly acknowledged the error and asked taxpayers to ignore the emails and check the portal instead. Scale was never disclosed.

The courts have said it plainly

COURT	DATE	FINDING
Bombay HC	24 Dec 2024	Software glitches denied eligible taxpayers the s.87A rebate; deadline extended to 15 Jan 2025
Rajasthan HC	24 Sep 2025	CBDT's refusal to extend held "arbitrary and violative of Articles 14 and 19(1)(g)"
Karnataka HC	25 Sep 2025	"Predictable governance is essential for compliance"
Gujarat HC	13 Oct 2025	Technical glitches, delayed utility releases, compliance bottlenecks
Punjab & Haryana HC	29 Oct 2025	Criticised CBDT inaction despite judicial directives; warned of contempt proceedings

Five High Courts, four of them in a single season, one contempt warning. Each CBDT extension followed within days of the corresponding order.

The government's own record contradicts the "stable" line

Answering **Lok Sabha Unstarred Question 60 on 20 July 2026**, the Ministry of Finance called the portal largely stable and cited the 1.22 crore-a-day throughput — and in the same answer disclosed that the Managed Service Provider has been penalised on four separate grounds:

- 1 Liquidated damages for missing the contractual July 2020 deployment date.
- 2 Performance penalties across **12 quarters** where service level scores fell below contract thresholds.
- 3 Penalties for application outages during peak filing in FY 2025-26.
- 4 Penalties triggered because **ITR deadlines had to be extended due to MSP-attributable failure** — which the government confirms occurred in FY 2025-26.

That fourth ground is the government formally attributing the September 2025 extension to vendor failure. Penalty amounts have never been disclosed.

Separately, CAG Report 14 of 2024 found outstanding demand had grown from ₹10.44 lakh crore (2016-17) to ₹19.35 lakh crore (2021-22), that **7,341 duplicate cases in sampled units alone overstated demand by ₹15,652 crore** — directly relevant to wrongful s.245 refund adjustments — and that the department declined records for ~7,974 cases and did not respond to 81% of the CAG's 2,156 audit queries.

Accessibility, which gets less attention than it deserves

- **No filing app.** The AIS app is view-only. In a mobile-first country, the filing flow, DSC steps and offline utilities are all desktop-bound. This is arguably the largest unaddressed gap.
- **Windows-and-Excel dependency** for the complex forms excludes Mac, Linux, ChromeOS and mobile-only users from ITR-2, ITR-3, ITR-5 and the audit forms.
- **Two languages.** Kar Saathi added real-time Hindi and English support in April 2026 — two of twenty-two scheduled languages. No Tamil, Bengali, Marathi, Telugu.
- **Senior citizens** are structurally disadvantaged by Aadhaar-OTP dependence: an outdated mobile linked to Aadhaar, or no smartphone, and verification simply cannot complete. The ITR-V post route survives but is slow.
- **Rural filers** needing stable broadband at peak, Aadhaar OTP, net banking or a DSC token are pushed toward paid intermediaries — which adds cost and opens a channel for the fraudulent deduction claims the NUDGE campaign now penalises.

In users' own words

Reddit is blocked from this research session, so none of what follows is from there. It comes from CAclubindia forum threads, TaxGuru article comment sections, app store

reviews, ICAI's formal submission, and press quoting taxpayers directly – which skews toward professionals, with the app stores as the one genuine consumer channel reached.

The string that defines the experience

One error message dominates every venue: *Something went wrong, please try again later*. It appears at filing, at verification, at AIS access, at download, in the mobile app. ICAI's own submission to CBDT lists as a formal defect: *"Error messages without explanation."*

On the last step, to verify and submit returns – "Something Went Wrong, Pls try Later".

CAclubindia forum

The portal shown no error but messaging something went wrong.

Manojiit Kanjilal · CAclubindia

Then the IT department should inform about it... wasting time of millions of Indians!

Sachin Grover · CAclubindia

The old website was user friendly but the new portal is time consuming.

Anne Jennifer Colaso · CAclubindia

The community's only remedy is retry-until-it-works. One respondent in the same thread put it flatly: *"I think there is no other option but to try again."*

When the portal actively lies about state

This is the most corrosive category, because the user cannot tell what is true.

Verified returns of last year shown not Verified and people are made to apply for condonation.

"Sasikumar" · TaxGuru comments – a display bug with legal consequences

Portal is saying that Aadhar is not linked to pan... when we are trying to link, portal is saying Aadhar is already linked.

"Sanjay Gupta" · TaxGuru comments – a contradiction loop with no exit

Bank Account is not getting verified. Always showing Under process.

"Jessyraj P" · TaxGuru comments

Prefilled data contains bank account details more than once... error message found "IFSC CODE PROVIDED DOES NOT MATCH WITH RBI LIST".

J D Thakker · TaxGuru – the portal prefills a value and then rejects its own prefill

Documented alongside these: a return filed but the dashboard still showing **File Now**, which on retry produces **Your Return is already submitted** ; the same return accepted twice; and refunds issued twice to some taxpayers.

Money leaves, challan does not arrive

The highest-severity failure in the whole system, and it is in ICAI's list verbatim: payments *"successfully debited... but valid challans are not generated"*, and

HTML Error page opened up after successful debit of amount . The user is out the money and still non-compliant, with a manual reconciliation path measured in weeks.

Professionals, on the record

Every day I wake up aggressively to work and set the target of filing so many Income Tax Returns, but the IT website just fails my target.

CA Harsh Jain · Business Standard, July 2024

Trying to download 26AS for 4.5 hours but unable to due to an error message saying "site can't reach". The site hasn't been working properly for the last 10 days.

Pradeep Dwivedi · Business Standard, July 2024

ICAI's enumerated defects, quoted: *frequent login failures · OTP not delivered or delivered with significant delay · forced logouts, especially while switching between client profiles · DSC not getting registered/updated on portal · PAN error displayed several times while trying to submit JSON file · validation errors in certain clauses (like clause 21 and 44) · continuous buffering makes it difficult to complete form filling · and Form 10AB saved data disappearing unexpectedly.*

Refunds — the variance, not the wait, is what enrages

I have filed ITR on June 12, and it's been more than 60 days, it's not processed yet.

Taxpayer quoted by Upstox, 2025 season

Why my income tax refund has still not come, 3 months completed.

Taxpayer quoted by Upstox

Some users get refunds in seven days. Others, filing the same week with the same form, wait three months — and taxpayers report watching family members get paid while their own identically-timed return sits untouched. Nothing anywhere in the UI explains why. The user cannot distinguish *queued* from *broken*, and in the absence of information assumes the worst.

The mobile app, rated by the people using it

3.8 ★

AIS for Taxpayers on Google Play, ~3,930 ratings

2.9 ★

the same app on the Apple App Store, 298 ratings

LOGS OUT in seconds. "Something Went Wrong" error messages frequently. USELESS due to UNFAIR LIMITATION of just 40 entries displayed.

Google Play review — three defects in one line, including an undocumented 40-row cap on AIS entries

Since many days for logging in only the Mobile OTP comes, Email OTP is not received. All the registered accounts are facing the same issue.

Google Play review — the app needs both OTPs, so one dead channel is a hard lockout

Every time it's asking PAN number, date of birth... even after complying with these steps successfully at installation and after creating MPIN.

Apple App Store review — the MPIN, the app's entire convenience premise, does not stick

I could easily download statements since past 1 or 2 years but now it has become completely inaccessible for visually impaired.

Google Play review — an accessibility regression

The official response, which became its own grievance

On 15 September 2025 — deadline day, with users reporting payment failures, AIS download failures and login errors — the department's public line was that the portal *"is working fine"* and that people should *"clear your browser cache or try accessing the portal through a different browser"*, adding that AIS/TIS was *"functioning without any issues"*.

Telling several million people to clear their cache, on deadline day, is a server-side defect being reassigned to the user. It also happens to be the same advice the department's own official error FAQ gives for **Session expired** and **Access Denied** — which means the advice is not a deflection so much as an admission.

Workarounds as evidence

A workaround is a bug with a name. These are the folk remedies the community has converged on — each one points precisely at a defect, and together they are the most useful diagnostic material available.

WHAT USERS DO	WHAT IT PROVES IS BROKEN
File at 3am, or "early morning or late night" — advised by TaxGuru's own glitch guide and by private filing sites	No capacity headroom. The system is provisioned below its own peak demand and everyone knows it.
Delete the bank account entirely and re-add it instead of clicking Revalidate — <i>"it will be validated within a minute"</i>	The Revalidate function does not work. Delete-and-recreate is the only working path and it is undocumented.
Abandon net-banking e-verification, use Aadhaar OTP after Invalid EVC and bank login pages failing to open	An entire officially-documented verification method is de facto dead, concentrating load further onto UIDAI.
Clear all cookies, use incognito — forum guidance states it plainly: <i>"the portal is known to store old session tokens that block new logins"</i>	Session state is entangled with client storage and goes inconsistent, with no server-side repair path.
Use Firefox specifically ; use a particular Windows version	Browser-specific JavaScript and rendering failures, untested outside a narrow matrix.
Uninstall and reinstall the AIS app , clearing cache and RAM — <i>"solves the problem 95% of the time"</i>	App-local state corrupts with no in-app recovery.
Resend the Aadhaar OTP two more times as standard practice	OTP delivery is lossy, and the design assumes it.
Wait 1–2 minutes on a blank screen before concluding a download failed	No loading state anywhere. Users cannot tell slow from broken — the single cheapest fix on this entire page.

WHAT USERS DO	WHAT IT PROVES IS BROKEN
Click "Download Form" before clicking Proceed to secure the acknowledgement	The acknowledgement is not reliably generated after submission.
Ask a relative in India to download your AIS and email it	AIS/TIS and 26AS appear to be geo-fenced, with no path at all for non-residents — who

Root causes, not symptoms

The complaint list is long, but it collapses into a small number of architectural decisions. The department's own published error FAQ is the most revealing document here — not for the errors, but for what it offers as resolutions.

The official error FAQ, read as an architecture diagram

ERROR THE PORTAL SHOWS	THE DEPARTMENT'S OWN FIX	WHAT THAT REVEALS
expected maxlength: 25, actual: 27	Edit your city field	A 27-character city is rejected at submit , not at entry. Validation lives on the far side o the transaction — and the prefill supplied the offending value.
ITD-EXEC-2003	Avoid special characters, avoid double spaces, do not copy-paste between fields	Unsanitised input reaching a backend that chokes on it. "Don't paste" is a human being asked to substitute for a missing normalise step.
Something went wrong	Start a new filing	Server-side draft state is not reliably recoverable. Losing an in-progress return is treated as routine.
Session expired · Access Denied	Clear history and cookies	Session state depends on client storage and has no repair path.

The five decisions everything traces back to

CAUSE 1

Synchronous coupling to systems it does not own

Eight external dependencies sit on the critical path: UIDAI for OTP, TRACES for 26AS, Insight for AIS, NPCI and every scheduled bank for validation and refunds, payment gateways for challans, thousands of reporting entities for prefill data.

A slow UIDAI should mean "OTP is taking longer — holding your session." Instead it means a timed-out session and lost work. A TRACES outage should mean "prefill unavailable, continue manually." Instead it blocks. There is no visible evidence of circuit breakers, bulkheads, cached-stale prefill, or queue-and-callback on any of these paths.

CAUSE 2

Payment and challan are not one transaction

The debit and the challan record are written independently, with no idempotency key, no compensating action, and no user-visible middle state. A genuinely three-state operation — *paid, challan pending, failed* — is shown to the user as a binary. When the third state occurs, the interface has no vocabulary for it, so it renders an error page over a completed debit.

CAUSE 3

Schema version as a gate, not a contract

Utilities and JSON schemas arrive late — ITR-2 and ITR-3 in July, ITR-5 and ITR-6 in August, against a 31 July deadline — and then get revised mid-season, invalidating work already prepared. There is no forward compatibility and no migration path: a return built on v1.2 is rejected by v1.3 rather than upgraded. The official remedy is "download the latest utility and start again."

CAUSE 4

The emSigner local-daemon model

Signing requires a helper process on the user's own machine, listening on localhost across ports 1585, 2095, 2568, 2868 and 4587, serving HTTPS with a certificate the browser must be manually taught to trust. Its reliability is a function of the user's OS patch level, antivirus, firewall, browser release channel, Java install and token vendor's driver.

That compatibility matrix is unbounded. It cannot be engineered to an SLA — only removed. And a screen-reader user cannot complete this flow at all.

CAUSE 5

THE PRECONDITION

Four systems pretending to be one

e-Filing, TRACES, Compliance/Insight and the Reporting Portal are separate contracts to separate vendors from separate eras. The taxpayer experiences that procurement history as four logins, four session models, four availability windows and two sources of truth that disagree.

AIS-versus-26AS mismatch is not a bug. It is the predictable arithmetic of two systems independently materialising overlapping views of the same underlying facts.

Architectural opacity

No published stack, no architecture document, no status page history, and **no technical postmortem for any incident, ever**. The one public capacity claim — 1 crore ITRs a day — is almost certainly a load test against the submission endpoint, while every documented failure is in the fan-out around it: login, OTP, prefill, AIS, challan, DSC, save.

By contrast GSTN published its technology architecture, its API contract and its scaling model. That is the difference between a system that can be held to account and one that can only be complained about.

What has genuinely improved

Not everything is broken, and the gains are large enough to state plainly.

~10 days

average ITR processing time, down from ~93 days in 2013-14

3×

daily throughput gain year on year — 42.6 lakh/day peak in 2025 to 1.22 crore in July 2026

57 → 28

days average CPGRAMS grievance resolution in FY 2025-26

- **Season pace.** By 21 July 2026: 3.2 crore returns filed, 94% verified, 60% already processed; of 1.3 crore refund claims, 96% verified and 40% processed.
- **Prefill** now covers salary, TDS, interest, dividend and increasingly capital gains. The complaint is data quality, not the concept.
- **AIS and TIS** (Nov 2021) with a taxpayer feedback loop and a mobile viewer are a real transparency gain over Form 26AS alone.
- **Contractual enforcement.** The department has repeatedly penalised its vendor rather than absorbing failures quietly.
- **The structural fix.** Finance Act 2026's staggered statutory due dates — 31 Jul, 31 Aug, 31 Oct, 30 Nov — directly attack the peak-load concentration and calendar collisions that

professional bodies had raised for five straight years. If it holds, it is the most meaningful systemic response yet.

Nine things this system has to get right

Before any specific fix: these are the properties a tax portal must have, stated as requirements rather than features. Everything in the next section is in service of one of them.

- 1 **Never lose the user's work.** A return in progress represents hours of a person's life and, for a CA, a client relationship. "Start a new filing" must never appear as a resolution.
- 2 **Never take money without producing a receipt.** A debit with no challan is not a glitch, it is a financial and legal injury. The system must be able to say "we have your money, the challan is coming" — and then produce it.
- 3 **Never lie about state.** If a return is filed, say filed. If a refund is held, say why and by what. A wrong status is worse than a missing one, because the user acts on it.
- 4 **Degrade, don't fail.** When UIDAI is slow or TRACES is down, the correct behaviour is reduced function with an honest explanation — not a dead session and lost data.
- 5 **Fail with information.** Every error must say what went wrong, which field or system caused it, and what the user should do next. **Something went wrong** is not an error message; it is the absence of one.
- 6 **Validate where the user is typing.** Anything knowable at entry must be caught at entry. Rejection at submit, after an hour of work, is the single most demoralising pattern in the product.
- 7 **Work on a phone.** The country is mobile-first and the portal is not. Any flow that structurally cannot exist on a phone — a Windows-only daemon, an Excel macro — is a flow that excludes most of the population.
- 8 **Don't make the citizen compose what you already know.** The department holds the salary, TDS, interest, dividend and securities data. The default should be a completed return the taxpayer confirms, not a blank one they fill and then argue with.

- 9 **Be inspectable.** Published architecture, published incident reports, a live status page, real per-dependency availability numbers. Without this, nothing above can be verified by anyone outside the vendor.

One framing note. Two-thirds of this portal's users owe no tax at all — they are here to reclaim TDS or produce a document for a lender. For most of its user base this is not a tax-collection system, it is a **refund and documentation system**. Design decisions that treat every user as an adversarial filer, rather than a claimant waiting on their own money, get the emotional register of the product wrong — and that mismatch is audible in every quote in this document.

How to fix each one

Eleven interventions, ordered by severity times tractability. Each names the failure it closes, the change, and what it costs to attempt.

CRITICAL 1. Make payment and challan a single atomic transaction

Closes: debited-with-no-challan · HTML error page over a successful debit

THE CHANGE

- Assign an **idempotency key** at CRN generation, carried through the gateway round-trip, so a retry can never double-charge and a duplicate callback can never double-record.
- Model the payment as a **saga with compensation**, not a request-response. Persist intent before redirecting to the bank; reconcile on callback, on a poll, and on a scheduled sweep.
- Introduce a real third state in the UI: **Payment received, challan pending** — with the CIN arriving by push when it lands. Users can already tolerate a delay; what they cannot tolerate is an error page over their money.
- Run an automated reconciliation job against bank settlement files with a published SLA — say, unmatched debits resolved within 24 hours — and surface its state on the user's payment history.

EFFORT

Moderate. This is well-trodden payments engineering, and UPI/NPCI already demonstrates the pattern at far higher volume within the same country's stack.

WHY FIRST

It is the only failure mode that causes direct financial loss plus a compliance liability, and the reconciliation path today is manual and measured in weeks.

CRITICAL 2. Server-side autosave, so work cannot be lost

Closes: "start a new filing" as an official remedy · saved Form 10AB data disappearing · forced logout losing a half-finished return

THE CHANGE

- **Autosave every field change server-side**, versioned, keyed to the user and the return — not to a browser session and not to client storage.
- On any session loss, resume at the last saved state with a visible "restored your draft from 14:32" confirmation. Session expiry becomes an inconvenience rather than a catastrophe.
- Keep a short draft version history so a user who breaks something can step back, and so support can see what the user actually entered.
- Decouple session identity from client cache entirely, which removes "clear your cookies" from the support vocabulary.

EFFORT

Moderate, and largely additive — it does not require re-architecting the filing flow, only persisting it.

SECOND-ORDER GAIN

It also fixes the CA multi-client workflow: switching profiles stops being destructive once drafts live on the server rather than in the tab.

CRITICAL**3. Circuit breakers and graceful degradation on every external dependency**

Closes: OTP arriving after the session has already expired · AIS/26AS "service unavailable" blocking filing · cascading deadline-day collapse

THE CHANGE

- **Bulkhead each dependency** — UIDAI, TRACES, Insight, NPCI, gateways — so a slow one consumes its own thread pool and cannot starve the rest of the application. Most deadline-day "the portal is down" events are one dependency exhausting shared capacity.
- **Break the OTP race.** Hold the session open while an OTP is outstanding, and never let a session expire between issuing a challenge and receiving the answer. This one change removes a large share of ICAI's login complaints.
- **Serve stale prefill.** Cache each taxpayer's prefill snapshot; if TRACES or Insight is unavailable, serve the cached copy with a visible "as of 18 July" timestamp and let filing continue. Blocking a return because a read-only lookup is slow is indefensible.
- **Make everything over two seconds asynchronous** — acknowledge immediately, process in the background, notify on completion. This is exactly the pattern GSTN adopted, and it converts timeouts into waiting.
- Publish per-dependency availability on a public status page, so "is it me or the site?" stops being an unanswerable question asked several million times a day.

EFFORT

Significant but incremental — it can be rolled out one dependency at a time, starting with UIDAI, which carries 94% of all verification.

BIGGEST SINGLE WIN

This is the root cause behind the largest share of documented symptoms. Nothing else on this list moves the reliability number as much.

HIGH 4. Move validation to the point of entry

Closes: 27-character city rejected at submit · ITD-EXEC-2003 on pasted text · schema errors after an hour of work

THE CHANGE

- Make the JSON schema the **single source of truth** and **generate the client-side validation from it**, so the browser and the server can never disagree. Today they demonstrably do.
- **Normalise instead of rejecting.** Trim whitespace, collapse double spaces, strip or transliterate problem characters on the way in. "Do not copy-paste" is an instruction that should never have been written; it is a missing `normalise()` call converted into user homework.
- **Guarantee prefill conforms to the submission schema by construction.** A system that populates a field with a value it will later reject has an internal contract violation, and the user pays for it.
- Validate progressively as the user moves between sections, so errors surface within seconds of the mistake rather than at the end.

EFFORT

Low to moderate, and unusually high-yield — much of it is generated code plus input sanitisation.

NOTE

This is the fix that most directly reduces support load, because it eliminates whole classes of ticket rather than making them easier to answer.

HIGH 5. Retire emSigner — move to eSign

Closes: the entire DSC failure family · localhost port conflicts · "restart the emSigner" · Java dependencies · total inaccessibility for screen-reader users

THE CHANGE

- Adopt **CCA-licensed eSign** as the default signing path for every signer class where it is legally sufficient. The signer authenticates by Aadhaar OTP or biometric; the key is generated inside an HSM at the eSign provider and destroyed after one use. **No hardware token, no local daemon, no browser dependency, no Java.** It is valid under the IT Act and India's own DigiLocker and fintech onboarding already run on it.
- For any signer class that genuinely requires a Class 3 token, replace the browser-to-localhost call with a **detached-signature upload**: the portal issues a hash, the user signs it with any

native desktop application, and uploads the signature blob over ordinary HTTPS. The hardware guarantee is preserved; the browser and localhost leave the trust path entirely.

- Restore **remote DSC filing**, which the current portal dropped — its absence broke the standard model of a CA signing from their own office on a client's behalf.

EFFORT

Moderate, and mostly integration rather than invention. The alternative already exists, is government-licensed, and is in production elsewhere in the same stack.

WHY IT MATTERS BEYOND RELIABILITY

The DSC flow is the portal's hardest accessibility failure. No amount of ARIA markup fixes a flow that requires installing a Windows daemon and clicking through a TLS interstitial — it has to be replaced, not remediated.

HIGH

6. Rewrite every error message, and instrument them

Closes: **Something went wrong** in all its appearances — the most-cited defect in every venue

THE CHANGE

- Every error gets three things: **what happened, which field or system**, and **what to do next**. "Your city name is 27 characters; the form allows 25. Shorten it here." Not a modal that says nothing.
- Attach a **reference ID to every error**, displayed to the user and searchable by the helpdesk. Today a support call begins with the agent having no idea what the user saw.
- Distinguish clearly between *your input is wrong*, *our system is busy — retry in a minute*, and *this is broken and we know*. Collapsing all three into one string is what makes users retry pointlessly for hours.
- **Instrument error frequency by code** and publish the top ten monthly. An error that fires a hundred thousand times a day is a product defect, and treating it as an individual support incident is how it survives five years.
- Add a loading state everywhere. Users currently wait on blank screens for two minutes because they were told to — the cheapest fix on this entire page.

EFFORT

Low. This is the highest ratio of user-perceived improvement to engineering cost anywhere in the plan.

CAUTION

Do it *after* fixes 1–4, or you simply produce well-written descriptions of failures that should not be happening.

HIGH

7. Treat schema version as a contract, not a gate

Closes: mid-season schema changes invalidating prepared returns · TAR JSON version errors · "download the latest utility and start again"

THE CHANGE

- **Freeze schemas before the season opens.** Publishing an ITR-5 utility in August against a filing deadline weeks later is a policy failure no engineering can absorb — and it is what turns the traffic curve into a spike instead of a plateau.
- **Accept the last N minor versions** with server-side up-migration for additive changes. Only genuinely breaking changes should reject.
- When a rejection is unavoidable, return a **field-level diff** — this field moved, this one is new — rather than a version mismatch code.
- Publish every schema as a versioned artifact with a **public changelog**, so software vendors and CAs can prepare rather than discover.
- Commit to a published release calendar: forms notified in month X, utilities and schemas available in month X, no revisions after month Y. Both ICAI and KSCAA have asked for exactly this, in writing, in consecutive years.

EFFORT

Low engineering, high organisational. The hard part is the discipline of freezing, not the code that supports it.

KNOCK-ON EFFECT

An early freeze widens the effective filing window from weeks to months, which flattens the deadline-day peak more cheaply than any amount of hardware.

HIGH 8. Make refund and processing status legible

Closes: "60 days and not processed" with no explanation · silent s.245 adjustments · watching a family member get paid first

THE CHANGE

- Replace *Under processing* with a **real state machine the user can see**: received → verified → in queue → under review (with the reason: AIS mismatch, high-value claim, NUDGE flag, demand set-off) → refund determined → sent to bank → credited or failed.
- **Show a position or an expected window.** Variance is what enrages people, not duration — a user told "returns filed in your week are being processed now, expect 10–14 days" stops filing grievances and stops posting.
- When a refund is held, **say what is holding it and give the action that releases it** — a deduction to substantiate, an AIS item to respond to, a bank account to revalidate.
- For a s.245 set-off, show the demand, its year, its origin, and a one-click path to dispute it — noting that CAG found 7,341 duplicate cases overstating demand by ₹15,652 crore in sampled units alone, so a meaningful share of these adjustments are against demand that should not exist.
- Fix the **Revalidate** button on bank accounts, or remove it and make the working delete-and-re-add path the documented one. Shipping a button that never works and letting a forum discover the workaround is its own kind of failure.

EFFORT

Moderate. Most of this state already exists internally; the work is exposing it honestly.

WHY IT IS NOT COSMETIC

For two-thirds of users the refund *is* the product. Grievance volume, helpline load and public anger are all downstream of this one opacity.

STRUCTURAL **9. Build a sanctioned public API and an intermediary ecosystem**

Closes: deadline-day load concentration · the portal being the only UI · third-party filers scraping a web app and looking like bots to the WAF

THE CHANGE

- Create an income-tax equivalent of GSTN's **GSP programme**: a versioned OAuth-secured API, a public sandbox, rate limits, and a vendor recognition scheme. GSTN explicitly recognised that an enterprise filing lakhs of invoices and a small trader filing five have irreconcilable UX needs, and let the market build the interfaces while the government owned the contract.
- The UK's Making Tax Digital goes further — HMRC runs the API and the tax logic and publishes a developer hub, and taxpayers use commercial software. HMRC's reliability problem is thereby bounded to a surface it fully controls.
- This converts today's scraper traffic — which is indistinguishable from abuse at the firewall — into **governable, attributable, rate-limited traffic**, and distributes both load and UX responsibility away from a single procurement.

EFFORT

Large, and as much policy as engineering. But it is the intervention that changes the shape of the problem rather than mitigating it.

PRECEDENT

India has already done this twice, well: UPI and GSTN. The pattern is proven domestically at higher volume.

STRUCTURAL **10. Default to a completed return, and put it on a phone**

Closes: the entire composition burden for ~72% of filers · desktop-only dependency in a mobile-first country

THE CHANGE

- **Invert the obligation.** Singapore's No-Filing Service pre-fills from mandatory employer submissions and the taxpayer confirms or does nothing; Estonia's e-Tax arrives pre-completed from connected registries and takes minutes. The design principle is that the reporting duty sits with the institution holding the data, and **the default outcome of doing nothing is a correct return.**
- India already has the data — AIS, SFT, TDS, the whole Insight pipeline. It then makes the taxpayer compose a return from scratch and argue with the prefill. For an ITR-1 filer with one employer and a savings account, filing should be a review-and-confirm, not a form.

- Move reporting from annual batch toward **real-time feeds**, as Australia's Single Touch Payroll does per pay run. This kills AIS-versus-26AS reconciliation mismatch at source rather than adjudicating it afterwards.
- **Ship actual mobile filing.** The department's only app is view-only and rated 2.9 stars on iOS. Once eSign replaces emSigner (fix 5), the last structural blocker to filing on a phone is gone.

EFFORT

Large, multi-year, and requires legislative and reporting-entity change alongside the software.

THE PRIZE

It removes most users from the peak entirely. A confirm-and-submit flow does not need an offline utility, a desktop, or forty minutes on deadline day.

STRUCTURAL **11. Single sign-on, one source of truth, and radical transparency**

Closes: four logins · AIS versus 26AS disagreement · the impossibility of holding anyone to account

THE CHANGE

- **One identity across e-Filing, TRACES, Insight and Reporting.** GIGW 3.0 already mandates single sign-on for government websites, which arguably makes the current split non-compliant with the government's own standard.
- Establish **one canonical income-facts store**, with AIS and 26AS as different *views* of it rather than independently materialised datasets. Two systems computing overlapping views of the same facts will always disagree; the fix is to stop having two.
- **Publish the architecture**, as GSTN did. **Publish incident postmortems** — there has never been one. **Publish a live status page** with per-dependency availability.
- Replace the "1 crore ITRs a day" capacity claim with **honest end-to-end metrics**: p95 login latency, OTP delivery success rate, prefill availability, challan generation success rate, error rate by code. The current number benchmarks the one endpoint that passes.
- Commission and publish a real **WCAG 2.1 AA audit**. The portal's accessibility statement claims WCAG 2.0 Level A, self-assessed; GIGW 3.0 requires 2.1 AA. That is a two-step gap on a service every working adult is legally compelled to use, and Level A does not even cover colour contrast.
- **Add languages.** Kar Saathi supports Hindi and English — two of twenty-two scheduled languages.

Sequencing

Ordered so that each phase makes the next one cheaper, and so that nothing user-visible ships before the thing underneath it is sound.

Phase 0

Stop the bleeding — one season. Atomic payments with idempotency and a reconciliation sweep (fix 1). Server-side autosave (fix 2). Loading states everywhere. A public status page. These are the changes that stop users losing money and work, and none of them require touching the tax logic.

Phase 1

Make failure survivable — one to two seasons. Circuit breakers and bulkheads, dependency by dependency, starting with UIDAI (fix 3). Schema-generated client validation and input normalisation (fix 4). The full error-message rewrite with reference IDs and published frequency data (fix 6). Refund state machine made visible (fix 8).

Phase 2

Remove the unfixable — one to two years. eSign migration and detached-signature upload, retiring emSigner (fix 5). Schema freeze discipline and a published release calendar (fix 7). A commissioned WCAG 2.1 AA audit, published in full.

Phase 3

Change the shape of the problem — multi-year. The sanctioned API and intermediary programme (fix 9). Single sign-on and a canonical income-facts store (fix 11). Real-time reporting feeds replacing annual batch.

Phase 4

The destination. No-touch returns for simple salaried cases, and genuine mobile filing (fix 10). At which point the July peak stops being an engineering problem, because most people are no longer filing — they are confirming.

One thing that is not on this list: more hardware. The government's own answer to the portal question is compute, storage, bandwidth and a war room. But the documented failures are not capacity failures — they are a missing `normalise()` call, a session that expires while waiting for its own OTP, a payment written without a transaction boundary, and a validation rule on the wrong side of the wire. You cannot buy your way out of any of those.

How you would know it worked

The current public metric — returns filed per day — measures whether people were forced to comply, not whether the system served them. These are the numbers that would actually show improvement, and none of them is published today.

METRIC	WHAT IT CAPTURES	TARGET SHAPE
Unmatched debits — payments with no challan after 24 hours	The severest failure class	Approaching zero, published monthly
Draft loss rate — sessions ending without a recoverable saved return	Whether work survives	Approaching zero
Submit-time rejection rate for conditions knowable at entry	Whether validation is in the right place	Falling toward zero as fix 4 lands
Frequency of the top ten error codes	Whether defects are being fixed or merely absorbed	Published; each one trending down
p95 latency and success rate per dependency — UIDAI, TRACES, Insight, gateways	Where the fan-out actually fails	Live on a status page
Refund time distribution , not the average	Variance — the thing users actually experience	A tight distribution beats a good mean
Share of returns filed before the final week	Whether the schema freeze flattened the peak	Rising every season
Share of returns filed on mobile	Whether the country's actual device is served	From ~zero to a majority
Grievances per lakh returns , and reopen rate	Whether "disposed" means resolved	Both falling — a disposal rate alone says nothing
Deadline extensions required	The honest summary metric	Zero. The government already penalises its vendor on this basis, so it

What could not be established

Stated explicitly, because the absence is itself informative.

NEVER PUBLISHED

- **Registered user count** — no CBDT, PIB or Parliament figure exists at any date. The 12.13 crore *taxpayer* count is the closest defensible proxy, with its definition attached.
- **Registered CA, ERI and TAN-deductor counts** — an RTI to the Directorate of Systems is realistically the only route.
- **Age distribution of filers** — held in every PAN record, never released.
- **City-level filing data** — state is the finest official granularity.
- **Unverified-return lapse rate** — never published.
- **Penalty amounts levied on the vendor** — disclosed as fact, never as figure.
- **The technical stack** — no public architecture document, no stated cloud or datacentre model, no CDN or WAF vendor, no RPO/RTO targets, no autoscaling policy, and **no technical postmortem for any incident**. GSTN published all of this; the income tax portal has published none of it.
- **Any accessibility audit** of the portal — no VPAT, no STQC certificate, no academic study. The accessibility statement is self-assessed.
- **Any dedicated CAG IT audit of IEC 2.0.** CAG has audited income tax administration extensively, but a systems

VERIFY BEFORE RELYING ON IT

- **The revised-return cutoff for AY 2026-27** — sources split between 31 Dec 2026 and 31 Mar 2027.
- **The audit-based vs form-based framing** of the Finance Act 2026 staggered deadlines. Misclassification costs the old-regime election and loss carry-forward, neither curable by revision.
- **The "nil tax" figures** — 5.58 crore (zero liability after rebate) and 1.22 crore (income below the exemption limit) are different definitions of different things. Never present them as one series.
- **Income-slab distribution** — the official AY 2023-24 ITR Statistics PDF has it; secondary compilations of it are unreliable.
- **Whether the portal menus have switched** to the new 2026 form numbers or still show the legacy ones behind them.
- **The ordinary salaried filer's voice.** Reddit, X and Quora were all inaccessible from this research session. The complaint material here comes from CA forums, tax-blog comment threads, app store reviews and press quotes — which over-represents professionals. The app stores are the one true consumer channel reached, and the 2.9-star iOS rating against 3.8 on Android is a lead worth pulling on its own.

audit of the portal itself could not be located.

Compiled 22 August 2026 from the Income Tax Department's own user manuals and FAQs on incometax.gov.in, CBDT and PIB releases, the department's Time Series Data, Lok Sabha replies, CAG Report 14 of 2024, High Court orders, and ICAI and KSCAA representations. Statutory positions change frequently — verify anything load-bearing against the primary source before acting on it.

Primary sources: incometax.gov.in · incometaxindia.gov.in · [TRACES](#) · [Compliance Portal](#) · [Reporting Portal](#)

This is a reference summary, not tax advice.